Persuasion and Learning: Exploring Tribal Engagement and the Politics of Federal Support

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Abstract

Subnational governments frequently lobby and consult with institutions that fund them, but it remains unclear how federally recognized tribal governments use these strategies to shape their relationship with the U.S. federal government. We distinguish two forms of tribal engagement: persuasion, aimed at changing what federal policy permits or provides, and learning, aimed at navigating policy as it stands. We develop a theoretical framework explaining variation in engagement as a function of tribal demand, wealth, and geography, and derive competing expectations for whether engagement increases the federal funding tribes subsequently receive. We test these expectations using original data on tribal lobbying disclosures and participation in the Tribal-Interior Budget Council (TIBC) from 2013 to 2021, paired with a newly constructed dataset of over 89,000 Department of the Interior transactions to tribal governments. Lobbying is well predicted by tribal enrollment, gaming investment, and proximity to professional representation; TIBC participation is not. Neither form of engagement shows a reliable return, consistent with an allocation structure anchored to historical baselines. These results provide evidence that the structure of funding, not the intensity of engagement, drives what tribes receive. This study contributes to the broader literature on Indigenous governance, lobbying, and intergovernmental resource allocation.

Keywords: Native American, Lobbying, Fiscal Federalism, Financial Aid, U.S. Federal Government

*Any remaining errors are the authors'.

Few governments in the United States rely on federal transfers as heavily as tribal nations do. States and localities finance themselves primarily through their own tax bases, supplemented by intergovernmental revenue. Tribal governments are positioned differently: their capacity to tax is constrained by limited and often contested tax bases (Mohr, Palmer, and Trostle 2024), and for many tribes federal transfers account for the majority of government spending. This dependence is not incidental. It is the fiscal expression of treaty obligations, trust responsibilities, and a long history of political subjugation, and it persists despite decades of expanding tribal autonomy (Wilkins 2024). Because federal policy determines so much of what tribal governments can afford to do, tribes have strong incentives to engage the institutions that make it.

Scholarship on tribal political behavior has largely understood that engagement as persuasion. Tribes are analyzed as organized interests that lobby, contribute, testify, and litigate in order to move federal policy toward their preferences (Cornell 1990; Hansen and Skopek 2011; Boehmke and Witmer 2012; Carlson 2018). We argue that persuasion is only part of the story. Federal Indian policy is the accumulated product of Congress, the courts, and the bureaucracy, assembled over a history that oscillated between erasure, paternalism, and self-determination. Navigating that policy environment is itself difficult, and the returns to navigating it well are substantial. Tribes therefore have reason to engage federal institutions not only to change what policy permits, but to learn what it already permits, including which programs are available, how to access them, and what to anticipate as budgets shift (Evans 2011). Persuasion aims to move policy. Learning aims to operate more effectively within it. The two are not mutually exclusive, but they impose different costs, promise different benefits, and should appeal to different kinds of tribes.

This distinction motivates two questions. First, which tribes pursue persuasion-oriented engagement, and which pursue learning-oriented engagement? Second, what are the financial returns to each? Given the centrality of federal transfers to tribal governance, funding is the most plausible material payoff to either, which permits a direct comparison of the two forms of engagement against a common outcome.

We study two forms of engagement characteristic of each logic. For persuasion, we collect tribal federal lobbying activity from disclosure records. For learning, we collect participation in the Tribal-Interior Budget Council (TIBC), a forum in which tribal representatives and Department of the Interior officials meet several times each year to discuss the federal budget, program access, and the obstacles tribes encounter in using existing policy. To measure returns, we construct the first dataset linking federal transfers to individual tribal governments, drawn from just under 90,000 Department of the Interior transactions between 2013 and 2021.[1]

We find, first, that tribes sort into the two forms of engagement on different bases. Tribes that lobby have larger enrollments and land bases, are more heavily invested in gaming, and are located closer to major cities and airports rather than being more geographically isolated. Participation in TIBC is poorly predicted by the same characteristics, with enrollment its only consistent correlate. Participation in TIBC appears to rest on considerations other than the structural need and resource endowments that predict lobbying.

Second, and contrary to what a returns-to-engagement account would predict, we find little evidence that either form of engagement increases the federal funding tribes receive. In models with tribe-specific time trends, the estimated returns to lobbying and to TIBC participation are statistically indistinguishable from zero; without trends they are, if anything, negative. The pattern holds for total funding and across most functional categories. We argue that this reflects the structure of tribal-federal finance and the purposes engagement serves. Where allocations are largely formula-bound, engagement is better understood as protective and informational than as a means of extracting additional resources (Carlson 2018).

These findings speak to three literatures. By treating engagement as a process of learning as well as persuasion, we connect tribal governance to broader accounts of how governments in federal systems acquire and act on information (Boehmke and Witmer 2004; Shipan and Volden 2008; Evans 2011). By documenting limited financial returns where prior work has found substantial ones, we identify a scope condition on the intergovernmental lobbying literature (Payson 2021), where returns to engagement depend on how much discretion exists in the funding stream

[1]Our analysis examines only federally recognized tribes in the contiguous United States.

being targeted. Where allocations are formula-bound, engagement should be expected to serve other ends. Finally, by assembling original data on federal transfers to tribes, we provide the most detailed quantitative account to date of the tribal-federal fiscal relationship, situating tribal nations within the study of intergovernmental transfers and fiscal federalism (Rodden 2006; Weingast 2009; Nugent 2012; Anderson and Parker 2017).

The paper proceeds as follows. We first describe the historical development of the tribal-federal fiscal relationship and document its contemporary scale. We then develop a theory of tribal engagement that distinguishes persuasion from learning and derives expectations about which tribes pursue each. After describing our data on tribal characteristics, engagement, and federal transfers, we present results on the correlates of engagement and on its financial returns. We conclude by considering what limited financial returns imply for how we understand tribal political strategy and the fiscal architecture of federal Indian policy.

Explaining the Tribal-Federal Fiscal Relationship

A Brief History

The financial relationship between tribes and the federal government has taken several distinct forms. In the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, the United States entered into treaties with Native nations that frequently included provisions for financial support, whether as annuities or as compensation for ceded land (Wilkins and Stark 2017). Implementation was inconsistent, marked by delays, corruption, and disputes over terms.[2] As the relative power of the United States grew, treaty terms became progressively less favorable to Indigenous nations (Spirling 2012).

After treaty-making ended and assimilation policy failed to improve conditions in Indigenous communities, federal policy changed course. The Indian Reorganization Act of 1934 moved away

[2]The nineteenth-century Senator William Windom repeatedly criticized the federal government's failure to honor treaty obligations, resisting efforts by other members of Congress to cut appropriations meant to fulfill them and arguing that most Indian wars originated in the failure to comply with agreements made with tribes (Salisbury 1987).

from assimilation and toward the recognition of tribal sovereignty, re-establishing the role of tribal governments in Indigenous communities (Wilkinson 2005). Most consequentially, it provided a mechanism for tribes to establish governing bodies recognized by the federal government, laying the groundwork for the modern government-to-government relationship (Rusco 2000).

The Indian Self-Determination and Education Assistance Act (ISDEAA) of 1975 transformed that relationship again. ISDEAA allowed tribal governments to contract with the Department of the Interior and the Department of Health and Human Services to administer programs in their own communities using federal appropriations, substantially expanding the governing capacity of tribal administrations (Stuart 1990; Johnson and Hamilton 1994; Witmer and Green N.d.). Amendments in 1988 and 1994 extended the model further, giving many tribes broader authority over how funds are used (Delaney 2016).[3]

Self-determination contracting remains central to tribal-federal finance, but federal transfers to tribes now span a wide range of policy areas and agencies. They include grants, loans, and technical assistance supporting business development, environmental conservation, infrastructure, wildfire prevention, language revitalization, tribal elections, and health screening. Taken together, these funds are integral to the economies of many tribes and reservations (Ratté and Anderson 2022). While the Department of the Interior (DOI) and Health and Human Services (HHS) remain the principal actors, the Departments of Labor, Agriculture, and Transportation also maintain financial relationships with tribal governments, and the Treasury administered the emergency funding directed to tribes during the COVID-19 pandemic (Akee, Henson, Jorgensen, and Kalt 2020).

In this paper, we focus on the Department of the Interior for two reasons. First, the agencies with the broadest administrative responsibility for federal Indian policy, the Bureau of Indian Affairs (BIA) and the Bureau of Indian Education (BIE), are located within it, as are other agencies with frequent tribal contact including the Fish and Wildlife Service, the Bureau of Reclamation,

[3]Providing tribal governments with federal funds to administer federal programs was advocated much earlier by Felix Cohen, the legal architect of the Indian Reorganization Act, but did not ultimately make it into the final version of the bill (Rusco 2000).

and the National Park Service (Lambert 2016). Second, Interior is the department whose budget is the explicit subject of the consultative forum we study, allowing us to observe engagement and funding within the same institutional arena.[4]

The Scale of Federal Support

Federal support is consequential for tribal governments in part because reservations present persistent obstacles to private investment, with well-documented economic consequences (Anderson and Parker 2008; Wellhausen et al. 2017; Leonard and Parker 2021; Bauer, Feir, and Gregg 2022; Brouwer 2024). Where private capital is difficult to attract, reservation economies rest on two principal sources, transfers from the federal government and tribally owned enterprise (Ratté and Anderson 2022). Some tribes command sufficient own-source revenue to sustain considerable fiscal independence, but for most, federal support is a critical component of governing capacity.

Tribal governments are also constrained in their capacity to raise revenue through taxation in ways that state and local governments are not. Land held in trust by the federal government is exempt from state and local taxation under Section 5 of the Indian Reorganization Act, and it is

[4]Restricting attention to Interior means we do not observe the majority of federal dollars reaching tribal governments. As we document later, Interior accounted for a smaller share of Cherokee Nation spending than the Indian Health Service in every year we observe, and during the pandemic the Treasury administered transfers larger still. We do not regard this as undermining the study. Interior is the most likely department in which to observe returns to engagement, because it houses the agencies with primary responsibility for the programs tribes engage federal officials about. If engagement does not move Interior funding, there is little reason to expect that it moves funding in departments where no comparable consultative body operates. Several of the largest non-Interior streams are in any case poorly suited to detecting political returns: a substantial portion of IHS funding represents revenue generated by tribally operated clinics rather than appropriated transfers, HUD's block grants are distributed according to a published formula, and pandemic-era Treasury allocations were governed by statutory criteria during a single anomalous period.

likewise unavailable to tribes as a property tax base.[5] Where tribes do tax on-reservation activity, they frequently do so alongside states rather than in place of them. In *Cotton Petroleum Corp. v. New Mexico*, the Supreme Court held that a state could impose severance taxes on the same non-Indian on-reservation production already subject to tribal severance taxes, leaving producers on the Jicarilla Apache reservation facing a combined burden substantially higher than they would have faced elsewhere in the state.[6] Tribal authority over nonmembers is further limited. Under *Montana v. United States*, tribes generally lack civil authority over nonmembers on non-Indian fee land within reservation boundaries, and the Court extended that rule to taxation in *Atkinson Trading Co. v. Shirley*, invalidating a Navajo Nation hotel occupancy tax on that basis.[7]

The consequences are visible in the composition of tribal revenue. Census data on state and local government finance indicate that roughly 51 to 54 percent of combined state and local revenue came from taxation between 2018 and 2021, and 22 to 28 percent from federal transfers (U.S.

[5]The exemption attaches to trust status rather than to reservation boundaries. Land held by tribes or their citizens in fee patent, including fee land within reservation boundaries, is generally subject to state and local property taxation (*County of Yakima v. Confederated Tribes and Bands of the Yakima Nation, 502 U.S. 251* 1992).

[6]Combined tribal and state severance taxes reached 14 percent of gross value against 8 percent off-reservation (*Cotton Petroleum Corp. v. New Mexico, 490 U.S. 163* 1989). The practical consequence of concurrent authority is that tribal taxation raises the total cost of on-reservation economic activity rather than drawing on an otherwise untaxed base, which constrains what tribes can levy without deterring the activity itself.

[7]*Atkinson* did not disturb tribal taxing authority on trust land, where it remains substantial (*Merrion v. Jicarilla Apache Tribe, 455 U.S. 130* 1982). The constraint is jurisdictional rather than general, but it binds most tightly on precisely the commercial activity that would otherwise be most taxable.

Census Bureau 2023).[8] Substantial federal dependence is not unique to tribal governments. Among state governments, the federal share of general revenue reached a record 36.7 percent in fiscal 2021, and federal funds rather than state taxes were the largest single revenue source in 15 states that year, up from five in fiscal 2019 (Pew Charitable Trusts 2024, 2025).[9]

What distinguishes tribal governments is not that they receive federal money but that they have so little else to draw on. Comprehensive data on tribal finances do not exist, but the available evidence points well past the state and local range. A survey of tribal governments in Montana found that approximately 2 percent of tribal government revenue came from taxes (Mohr, Palmer, and Trostle 2024).

The Cherokee Nation offers one of the few opportunities to observe the federal share directly, as one of a small number of tribes that make budgets publicly accessible. Because the Cherokee Nation is the largest tribe by enrollment and operates several successful enterprises, its budgets likely represent a floor estimate of federal reliance, and smaller tribes with fewer economic resources should be more dependent still. Figure 1 plots the share of each Cherokee Nation budget justified through federal sources from fiscal year 2012 to 2023. Federal sources accounted for 57 to 89 percent of all tribal spending over this period. This share is inflated by Indian Health Service funds, much of which represents revenue generated by tribally operated clinics and health services.

[8]Figures are calculated from general revenue, which excludes utility, liquor store, and insurance trust revenue. Shares differ substantially depending on the unit of analysis. Considering state governments alone, federal funds constitute a larger share of revenue than they do for state and local governments combined, since local governments draw heavily on property taxes that states do not levy.

[9]The pandemic marks the high point of this series. Federal funds were the largest revenue source in 18 states in fiscal 2020, the most on record, and the share has declined in each subsequent year, falling to 34.2 percent of state revenue by fiscal 2024 (Pew Charitable Trusts 2026). Because our panel spans fiscal years 2013 through 2021, it captures both the pre-pandemic baseline and this anomalous period.

Excluding IHS sources reduces the federal share to 38 to 86 percent, still well above what state and local governments draw from intergovernmental sources. Interior funds alone accounted for 4 to 13 percent of the total budget, averaging roughly 8 percent per year, a larger share than any federal department other than IHS and, during the pandemic, the Treasury.[10]

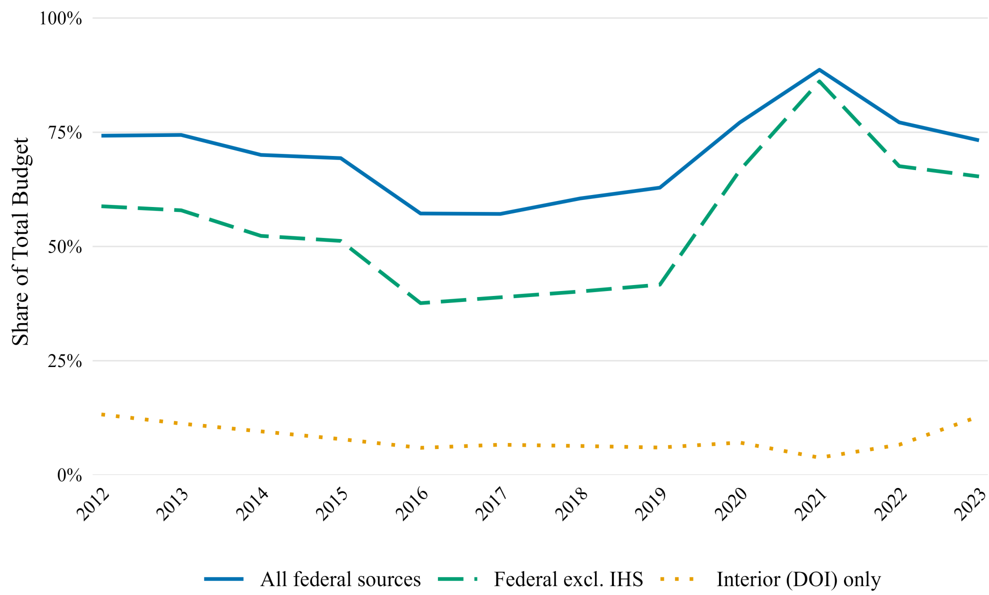

Figure 1: **Cherokee Nation Budget by Federal Justification** Estimates calculated from publicly available Cherokee Nation comprehensive budgets, combining the operating and capital budgets.

Comparing federal transfers to revenue from tribal enterprise is difficult, as no systematic data on tribally owned businesses exist. Aggregate figures are available for gaming, the most prominent industry in which tribal governments participate. Between fiscal years 2013 and 2021, tribal gaming revenue rose from $28 billion to $39 billion (National Indian Gaming Commission 2023), while Interior transferred between $1.1 and $2.9 billion to gaming tribes over the same period, or roughly 4 to 7.5 percent of gaming revenue.[11]

These figures understate the importance of Interior funding in several respects. A substantial number of tribes operate no gaming business at all, so the comparison speaks little to their budgets.

[10]For information on funding from other federal departments, Appendix A breaks down Cherokee Nation budget justification by all federal departments.

[11]See Appendix B for a yearly comparison of Interior funding to gaming revenue.

Among those that do, revenue is highly concentrated. In fiscal year 2022, 8 percent of gaming operations accounted for slightly more than half of all gaming revenue (National Indian Gaming Commission 2023), meaning the aggregate comparison overstates the relative scale of gaming for tribes with smaller operations. Gaming revenue is also not tribal income. Operating a casino carries substantial costs that federal transfers do not, and state governments and private management partners may claim significant portions of the proceeds.

How Federal Funds Reach Tribes

The mechanisms by which Interior funds reach tribal governments bear directly on what political engagement can plausibly accomplish. Federal transfers to tribes are not, for the most part, competitively awarded on the basis of applications that advocacy might strengthen. A substantial share is distributed according to baselines established decades ago and carried forward with little systematic revision.

Tribal Priority Allocations (TPA) are the principal source of BIA funding for tribal governments at the reservation level. Tribes prioritize TPA funds across eight general categories, including tribal government operations, human services, education, public safety, community development, resource management, trust services, and general administration (Bureau of Indian Affairs 1999). Roughly two-thirds of TPA is distributed as base funding, allocated largely on the basis of historical funding levels rather than any current assessment of need. The remaining third, distributed as non-base funding for purposes such as road maintenance and housing improvement, is allocated according to specific program criteria (U.S. General Accounting Office 1998). The historical baseline itself dates to the levels set in BIA's fiscal year 1994 budget justification, and the process by which per-tribe amounts were originally determined is not well documented (Congressional Research Service 2023).[12]

The consequences of allocating on a historical basis are well documented and had been the

[12] Summarizing GAO's findings, Congressional Research Service (2023) reports that tribes had limited input into the initial TPA amounts proposed by BIA, though some were able to influence their levels through the initial tribal shares process.

subject of criticism for two decades by the time the General Accounting Office assessed the distribution in 1998. GAO found that base funding took no account of changing conditions, including tribes' levels of need or their revenues from nongovernmental sources. Illustrating the point, each of the six tribes reporting the highest own-source revenues received more TPA base funding than any of the sixteen tribes reporting no revenues or net losses (U.S. General Accounting Office 1998). Congress directed BIA to examine alternatives, but the resulting BIA-tribal workgroup recommended against redistribution, reporting that existing appropriations met roughly one third of identified need and that fewer than 10 percent of tribes commanded sufficient revenue to provide a full range of governmental services (Bureau of Indian Affairs 1999). The historical baseline therefore persisted not through inertia alone but through a considered judgment, shared by BIA and tribal representatives, that reallocating an inadequate appropriation would do little to address the underlying shortfall.

A parallel logic governs self-determination contracting. Under ISDEAA, a tribe assuming administration of a federal program receives the funds the federal government would otherwise have expended operating that program on the tribe's behalf, together with a proportionate share of the associated administrative funds held at agency, regional, and central office levels.[13] Amounts are carried forward across agreements and adjusted for changes in appropriations, and recent statutory reform has extended their durability further by permitting self-governance tribes to maintain the same funding agreement across many years.

The result is a funding environment in which the resources available to a given tribe in a given

[13]These administrative amounts are the "tribal shares" of the self-governance literature. Program funds themselves are calculated according to program-specific methodologies that may incorporate criteria such as tribal population and land area (Tribal Self-Governance Advisory Committee 2015). The relevant point for our purposes is not that every element is fixed, but that the amounts a tribe receives are anchored to what the federal government was already spending rather than determined through any process an individual tribe can readily contest.

year are largely determined before that year's political activity begins.[14] This has direct implications for what engagement should be expected to achieve. Where transfers are allocated through competitive processes, engagement that improves a tribe's standing with legislators or administrators might reasonably increase the funds it receives. Where allocations are anchored to historical baselines, the same engagement cannot move the aggregate, whatever else it accomplishes. This does not render engagement pointless. Baselines are established, revised, and occasionally threatened through political processes, and tribes that understand how funds are structured are better positioned to claim what is already available to them and to defend existing allocations against erosion. But the returns to engagement of that kind would not appear as growth in total transfers.

A Theory of Tribal Engagement: Persuasion and Learning

Tribal governments engage federal institutions for different reasons, and the reasons imply different activities. We distinguish two forms of engagement. Engagement oriented toward *persuasion* seeks to change what federal policy permits or provides, where tribes are able to communicate preferences to legislators and administrators in the hope of shifting decisions in their favor. Engagement oriented toward *learning* seeks to operate more effectively within policy as it stands: tribes gather information about what programs exist, how funds are structured, what is available to them, and what is coming. The distinction is analytic rather than exclusive. A tribal delegation in Washington may do both in a single afternoon. But the two forms impose different costs, promise different benefits, and should therefore appeal to different tribes.

The standard account of why subnational governments engage does not fit tribes. The literature on cities has framed the question in terms of representation, asking why governments lobby legislators who, in theory, already represent them (Payson 2021). For tribes, the premise behind

[14] We cannot characterize precisely how much of the funding we observe falls into each category. USAspending records do not distinguish competitively awarded transactions from those arising under formula, compact, or negotiated settlement, a limitation we return to below. This constraint is not unique to our data. A 2022 GAO assessment found that federal agencies, including BIA, lack consistent data on federal spending directed to tribes (Congressional Research Service 2023).

that framing does not hold. Tribal citizens vote in state and federal elections, at times with real influence (Huyser, Sanchez, and Vargas 2017; Herrick, Davis, and Pryor 2022), but that influence is attenuated at every step. Tribal voters face distinctive barriers to the ballot, including unaccepted identification, nontraditional addresses, distant polling places, and limited mail access (Schroedel 2020), and because tribes are typically small shares of any electorate, their electoral weight registers mainly in a small selection of close races (McCool 1985).

Tribal policy interests also do not find ready allies once votes are cast. Tribes pursue sovereignty, the authority to assert and protect their rights as governments, which frequently cuts against the interests of the non-tribal governments around them (Fletcher 2015), and surveys document low tribal trust in those governments (Schroedel, Berg, Dietrich, and Rodriguez 2020). The distrust appears warranted: the presence of a tribe in a district has little measurable effect on how members of Congress vote (Conner 2014), and even Native state legislators struggle to advance substantive pro-Indigenous policy (Blasingame, Hansen, and Witmer 2025). Tribes therefore cannot rely on representation to secure their interests, and have long pursued influence through other channels (Witmer and Boehmke 2007).

Further, the subnational lobbying literature has concentrated almost entirely on persuasion. Cities and states are understood to lobby when their preferences diverge from those of the governments that fund them (Goldstein and You 2017; Payson 2020*b*), when acute need demands intervention (Loftis and Kettler 2015), or when they seek to secure appropriations that would not otherwise arrive (Payson 2020*a*). Work on tribal politics has largely followed suit, treating tribes as organized interests pursuing favorable policy through lobbying, contributions, testimony, and litigation (Hansen and Skopek 2011; Boehmke and Witmer 2012; Carlson 2019, 2022). Learning has received less attention, though it is implicit in accounts of how subnational governments locate and occupy institutional niches within federal systems (Evans 2011) and in the broader diffusion literature's treatment of governments as observers of one another (Boehmke and Witmer 2004; Shipan and Volden 2008).

For tribal governments, learning-oriented engagement is plausibly more valuable than for other subnational actors. Federal Indian policy is unusually complex, assembled across two centuries by Congress, the courts, and the bureaucracy, and administered through agencies whose funding mechanisms are opaque even to those who work within them. The allocation structures described above are not published in any form a tribal administrator could readily consult. Knowing which programs exist, which are formula-bound and which retain discretion, how compacting affects a tribe's position, and what changes are pending in the appropriations cycle is itself difficult knowledge to acquire, and acquiring it plausibly affects what a tribe can obtain. Subnational governments already devote real resources to this kind of learning; tribes, for instance, invest substantially in the capacity to identify and successfully apply for federal grants (Evans 2011).

Each form of engagement has a characteristic institutional home. Persuasion, for tribes, is most visible in formal federal lobbying. Lobbying is one instrument among several. Long before it was available, tribes petitioned the federal government to enforce treaty terms and contest policies such as removal (Carpenter 2021; Blackhawk, Carpenter, Resch, and Schneer 2021), and they continue to pursue persuasion through the notice-and-comment stage of federal rulemaking (Dwidar 2022; Dwidar and Marchetti 2023), through testimony aimed at blocking harmful legislation (Carlson 2022), and through litigation. Formal lobbying and campaign contributions entered this repertoire largely with the revenues of tribal gaming, which supplied both the means to engage and, in the form of gaming interests requiring protection, a reason to (Hansen and Skopek 2011; Corntassel and Witmer 2008; Boehmke and Witmer 2012). Lobbying itself typically involves retaining an independent firm to represent a client's interests before Congress and the executive branch in Washington, with the firm reporting its activity back to the client. Tribes that retain such firms do so principally to communicate positions to federal lawmakers and to track legislation affecting tribal interests, seeking to protect existing tribal authority, to build support for favorable measures, and to block unfavorable ones (Carlson 2018). Lobbying is professionalized, purchased, and conducted remotely: a tribe engages a firm, and the firm's proximity to Washington substitutes for the tribe's.

Learning, in turn, is exemplified by participation in the Tribal-Interior Budget Council, formerly known as the Indian Affairs Tribal Budget Advisory Council. TIBC provides a forum in which tribes and Department of the Interior officials work together to formulate the annual Indian Affairs budget request (Bureau of Indian Affairs 2024). Twenty-four tribal officials serve on the council, two from each of the twelve BIA regions, alongside senior Indian Affairs officials, the Assistant Secretary for Indian Affairs as federal co-chair, and representatives from the Office of Management and Budget and the White House. Three tribal co-chairs are elected by the tribal representatives, and the protocol requires that they be chosen in a manner representative of direct service, self-governance, and contracting tribes (*Tribal/Interior Budget Council Protocol* 2017).[15] The council meets at least three times a year, in practice on a roughly quarterly schedule with most meetings in the Washington area and one hosted annually by a tribe elsewhere in Indian Country (Bureau of Indian Affairs 2024). Meetings run two to three consecutive days and are open to the public, though only members may bring motions and vote. Subcommittees seat additional tribal representatives to take up particular policy areas in greater detail, including a standing Budget Sub-Committee and Data Management Sub-Committee, alongside issue-specific subcommittees TIBC may establish and dissolve as needed.

TIBC advises Interior on budget formulation, fund distribution, and program management, which is persuasive in form. But its reach is bounded twice over. What participants help shape

[15] The TIBC protocol has been revised periodically. The version we cite identifies itself as adopted November 9, 2017, with a further edit finalized May 27, 2019, though the document's own signature page instead dates original adoption to August 4, 2010, in Tulsa, Oklahoma, an inconsistency in the source we are unable to resolve further. This version governed the council for all but the final weeks of our FY2013–2021 panel; a subsequent revision, adopted November 5, 2021, changed some of its provisions (*Tribal/Interior Budget Council Protocol* 2021). The two versions share the same membership structure, co-chair arrangement, and conflict-of-interest provisions, but differ in the length of Tribal Representative terms (two years under the earlier protocol, extended to three years in 2021) and in which meetings may be conducted remotely (special meetings only under the earlier protocol; both regular and special meetings under the 2021 revision).

is a budget request: Interior's proposal, which travels to OMB and ultimately to a Congress that appropriates as it sees fit. More consequentially, the council's own rules foreclose particularistic advocacy. Representatives advocate on behalf of the tribes of their region rather than their own, and the protocol provides that members will not present proposals creating an unfair advantage for their own tribe in the budget process, on the stated premise that representatives speak for the general benefit of Indian Country (*Tribal/Interior Budget Council Protocol* 2017). Whatever else TIBC is, it is not a venue in which a tribe may directly press its individual funding claims.

What the forum offers instead is information. Indian Affairs describes TIBC meetings as serving an educational function, informing tribes about the budget process and the status of initiatives across the federal government (Bureau of Indian Affairs 2024). Department officials describe available opportunities, explain how tribes may access departmental resources, and identify the structural obstacles preventing particular outcomes. Tribes arrive with problems they are seeking to resolve, whether funding an irrigation project or ensuring that grant applications are prepared correctly. Participation is nonetheless demanding. Representatives are appointed to two-year terms, are expected to attend all meetings, and may be replaced if they cannot, with an alternate permitted to substitute only once per budget formulation cycle (*Tribal/Interior Budget Council Protocol* 2017). The council's business requires the sustained attention of elected leaders and senior administrators across multi-day meetings, several times a year.

Lobbying and TIBC differ in what they demand of a tribe and in how they are distributed over time, and these differences track the forms of engagement they reflect. Lobbying requires money and a relationship with a firm; it asks nothing of a tribe's leadership beyond the decision to retain one, and it operates continuously. TIBC asks for the leadership itself. Its costs are borne in the time and attention of senior officials, which cannot be delegated to a hired professional, and its business is episodic, concentrated in a few multi-day meetings each year.[16] Persuasion, in this setting, is a

[16]Some TIBC participants are not in tribal leadership, but the vast majority are either the lead executive or hold high level political positions in their tribe. Tribal representatives and the three co-chairs are required to be tribal leaders.

standing arrangement conducted at a distance; learning is a series of occasions requiring presence.

The two forms are not cleanly separable in practice, and the imperfection runs in one direction worth noting.[17] An actor representing a tribe's interests in Washington is also positioned to observe what is coming, so persuasion-oriented engagement tends to carry an informational return even when information is not its purpose.

Expectations

We treat engagement as an investment tribes make when expected benefits exceed expected costs. Benefits rise with a tribe's demand for federal support and with the likelihood that engagement improves what it receives; costs vary with a tribe's resources and with the specific demands each instance of engagement imposes.

Demand for federal support. The most direct source of variation in expected benefits is the scale of what a tribe must fund. Tribes with larger populations must provide services to more people. Tribes with larger land bases must manage more territory, more natural resources, and more infrastructure across a wider area at greater cost. Both raise the value of any additional federal support and, with it, the value of activity that might secure it. Because both lobbying and TIBC participation could plausibly improve a tribe's position, demand should predict both.

Hypothesis 1 (Demand)**.** *Tribes with larger populations and larger land bases are more likely to engage in both lobbying and TIBC participation.*

[17]Persuasion and learning are also broader than the two instances through which we examine them. Tribes pursue persuasion through litigation, congressional testimony, participation in notice-and-comment rulemaking, and campaign contributions, and pursue learning through intertribal organizations, sustained relationships with regional BIA offices, and contact with other tribal administrations. Our expectations concern the two forms of engagement; the evidence that follows concerns two particular instances of them. Inference from one to the other requires that these instances be reasonably representative of their categories, an assumption we take up when we describe the data in detail.

Wealth and economic interest. Wealth cuts two ways. Greater own-source revenue reduces the marginal value of federal dollars, weakening the incentive to engage. But wealth also makes engagement cheaper in relative terms, particularly lobbying, which is purchased directly and which poorer tribes may simply be unable to afford. For lobbying the net effect is ambiguous on these grounds alone.

Gaming resolves the ambiguity in one direction. Tribes with substantial gaming operations are not merely wealthier; they hold a specific economic interest subject to federal and state regulation, and thus have something concrete to defend in Washington (Corntassel and Witmer 2008; Boehmke and Witmer 2020). This gives gaming tribes a reason to lobby that is independent of their general fiscal position, and it is a reason oriented toward protection rather than acquisition.

TIBC is different. Its costs fall on tribal leadership directly, in time and attention rather than in fees a wealthy tribe can absorb, and wealth does little to relieve them. Serving a term with a binding attendance obligation demands something a tribe cannot purchase. What wealth changes instead is the value of what is on offer: a tribe whose enterprises fund its government has less use for detailed knowledge of how to navigate federal budget processes.[18]

Hypothesis 2 (Gaming)**.** *Tribes with greater gaming investment are more likely to lobby.*

Hypothesis 3 (Wealth)**.** *Greater tribal wealth is not expected to increase TIBC participation.*

Geography. Retaining a lobbying firm requires knowing that lobbying is an available strategy, identifying suitable firms, and maintaining a relationship with professionals whose networks are

[18]The pattern in our data is consistent with this once tribal size is taken into account. Gaming tribes appear, on their own, more likely to hold a TIBC role, but this largely reflects the fact that larger tribes are both more heavily invested in gaming and more likely to participate in TIBC; once tribal size is accounted for, gaming carries no independent relationship to participation. Gaming's apparent relevance to TIBC is thus a byproduct of tribal scale rather than a direct consequence of wealth itself, consistent with our expectation that a tribe's economic interests, as distinct from its general capacity, do little to explain who takes up TIBC's demands.

concentrated in a handful of metropolitan areas. Tribes distant from cities are correspondingly distant from the professional infrastructure through which lobbying is arranged, and are also, on average, less likely to have the administrative staff who would initiate such arrangements (Brouwer 2024). Remoteness should therefore depress lobbying, not because Washington is far away, but because the market for representation is.

TIBC is insulated from this by design. Its seats are apportioned across the twelve BIA regions, with each region establishing its own process to nominate two representatives and an alternate, forwarded to the Regional Director (*Tribal/Interior Budget Council Protocol* 2017). A tribe in a remote region does not compete for access with tribes in better-connected ones; it competes with its regional neighbors, who face similar circumstances. Nor does distance impose the full burden it might otherwise: representatives are reimbursed for their participation through their BIA regional office, and special meetings may be conducted by video or telephone conference, a provision the 2021 revision extended to regular meetings as well.[19] Geographic remoteness is thus substantially, if not entirely, neutralized by institutional design in a way it is not for lobbying, where no such apportionment exists.

Hypothesis 4 (Geography and Lobbying)**.** *Tribes located farther from major cities and transportation infrastructure are less likely to lobby.*

Hypothesis 5 (Geography and TIBC)**.** *Distance from major cities and transportation infrastructure is not expected to predict TIBC participation.*

Financial returns. If engagement is an investment, it should yield something. The subnational lobbying literature has generally found that it does: cities that lobby secure more state funding (Payson 2020*a*), and intergovernmental lobbying more broadly is understood to produce measurable fiscal returns (Goldstein and You 2017; Jensen 2018). Applied to tribes, this implies that sustained engagement of either kind should increase the federal funds a tribe receives.

Hypothesis 6 (Fiscal Returns)**.** *Tribes that engage in lobbying or TIBC participation receive more*

[19] See previous footnote on protocol versions.

federal funding over time.

Two considerations suggest a competing expectation. The first is structural. Where the bulk of a tribe's federal support is anchored to baselines set decades earlier and carried forward, no amount of engagement in a given year can move it. The second is institutional and applies to TIBC specifically: a forum whose rules prohibit members from seeking advantage for their own tribes is not one in which we should expect participation to produce tribe-specific returns. Lobbying is therefore the more demanding test of the two, and TIBC the case where a null result would be least surprising.

Under these conditions engagement may still be rational, but its returns would take forms that aggregate transfers do not capture: preventing erosion of existing allocations, accessing programs a tribe was already eligible for, or positioning for changes in the appropriations environment. Carlson's account of tribal lobbying as a strategy of resilience rather than acquisition points in the same direction (Carlson 2018).[20]

Hypothesis 7 (Allocative Constraint)**.** *Engagement does not increase the aggregate federal funding tribes receive.*

Data and Research Design

Testing our hypotheses requires three categories of data: tribal characteristics that our theory identifies as predictors of engagement, measures of the two instances of engagement themselves, and federal transfers to each tribe. This section describes each in turn, connecting every measure to the hypothesis it is built to test, before turning to how we estimate the correlates of engagement and its returns.

[20]These expectations are not symmetric, and we do not treat them as equally testable. Failure to detect an effect cannot by itself establish that none exists. But the two are distinguishable in their implications: if the fiscal returns account is correct, sustained engagement should produce detectable growth in transfers, and its absence across specifications, funding categories, and both instances of engagement would be difficult to reconcile with it.

Tribal Characteristics

Hypotheses 1 through 5 predict engagement as a function of tribal demand, wealth, and geography. High-quality demographic data on tribes is difficult to come by: most tribes do not systematically release such data, small reservation populations are hard to track with survey-based measures, and even the Decennial Census struggles with undercounting native populations. Our primary source is the Department of Housing and Urban Development's Indian Housing Block Grant formula data (IHBG), which combines American Community Survey estimates with tribe-provided data and corrections, and is updated more frequently than the Census.

To measure demand (H1), we use two population measures and two measures of territorial scale. Tribal enrollment, functionally citizenship for tribal nations, captures the total population a tribe governs regardless of where its members live.[21] Because enrolled members may live far from tribal land, and for many tribes only a minority live near the reservation, we separately measure the service area Indian population, a count of all AIAN persons living on or near the reservation. Alongside these, we measure total reservation land area and water area as reported by the Census Bureau, capturing the scale of territory a tribe must manage. We also pull, from IHBG data, the number of reservation households with income below 30% of median U.S. income. We divide this number by the AIAN population to get a measure of extreme poverty.

Gaming investment tests Hypotheses 2 and 3 jointly, with opposite expected signs: gaming should predict lobbying specifically (H2), while TIBC participation is not expected to respond to wealth generally (H3). We measure gaming as the total number of slot machines a tribe operated in a given year, pulled from an online directory of gaming establishments.[22] We use slot machine counts rather than a binary gaming indicator or a count of gaming locations because slot machines are the primary revenue driver in tribal gaming and better capture variation in the scale of a tribe's

[21]Enrollment is based solely on tribe-provided counts, but most tribes update these only every few years for IHBG allocation purposes. We adjust yearly estimates as a linear function between years in which a tribe submitted a new count.

[22]https://www.gamingdirectory.com

investment: a tribe can generate substantial revenue from a single large facility or comparatively little from several small ones, a distinction a binary or location-count measure would miss.

Geography tests Hypotheses 4 and 5, again with opposite expected signs: distance should depress lobbying, given the concentration of lobbying firms and professional networks in a handful of metropolitan areas (H4), but should not depress TIBC participation, given the council's regional apportionment (H5). We calculate the distance between each tribe's headquarters and the nearest city with a population of at least 100,000 as of 2010, the nearest commercial airport, and Washington, D.C., where most TIBC meetings are held. We also include indicators for each tribe's BIA-designated administrative region, both to capture regional variation not reflected in the distance measures and to distinguish overall geographic remoteness from the specific institutional apportionment TIBC uses.

All non-binary covariates are logged to normalize their distribution given substantial skew in their underlying measurement.

Measuring Engagement

Our theory distinguishes two forms of engagement, persuasion and learning, and we measure each through one characteristic instance: tribal lobbying and participation in the Tribal-Interior Budget Council (TIBC), respectively.

Persuasion: Lobbying

We measure persuasion-oriented engagement using federal lobbying activity from OpenSecrets.org.[23] While OpenSecrets tracks total spending and the number of lobbyists retained per reporting period, we dichotomize this into an indicator for whether a tribe retained a lobbyist in a given year, rather than modeling spending continuously, for three reasons. First, our theory treats

[23]There are drawbacks to lobbying as a measure of persuasion-oriented engagement. Not all lobbying activity is disclosed or easily attributable to specific tribes, which would bias any effect we detect toward zero rather than away from it. Lobbying data also cannot capture informal or grassroots advocacy, another form of persuasion-oriented engagement that is difficult to collect systematically across tribes.

the decision to retain a firm as the theoretically meaningful step where it is the discrete point at which a tribe pays the fixed cost of learning that lobbying is available and forming a relationship with representation, not the marginal dollar spent thereafter. Second, disclosed expenditure aggregates spending across every issue a tribe engaged a firm on, not spending specific to Interior; a continuous measure would conflate the breadth of a tribe's broader lobbying relationship with its engagement on the matters this paper addresses, while a binary indicator asks the cleaner question of whether that relationship existed at all. Third, a binary measure keeps lobbying comparable in form to our TIBC measure below.[24]

Learning: TIBC

We measure learning-oriented engagement through tribal participation in TIBC, an advisory body where tribal and DOI representatives meet three to four times yearly to discuss the federal budget. The National Congress of American Indians describes the council's mission as promoting tribes' self-determination, self-governance, sovereignty, and treaty rights, alongside sufficient levels of funding to address the needs of Tribes and their tribal citizens (National Congress of American Indians 2026). TIBC seats three tribal co-chairs and two representatives per BIA region.[25] It further seats representatives on standing and issue-specific subcommittees, including Budget; Land, Water and Natural Resources; Data Management; Transportation; Education; Public Safety and Justice; and, most recently, Economic Development. Using publicly available directories, we code each tribe as participating in TIBC in a given year if a member served as co-chair, regional representative (and listed alternates), or subcommittee chair or voting member. This measure is imperfect: tribes may attend TIBC meetings without holding a formal role, those with formal roles may neglect to attend, and general attendance is not publicly recorded. Additionally, directories

[24]We assess the sensitivity of our returns-to-engagement results to this choice directly, distinguishing tribes with yearly lobbying expenditure at or above the 75th percentile ($100,000) of the pooled sample from other lobbying tribes in Appendix C.

[25]This includes two representatives for the Navajo region, which includes only the Navajo Nation; a Navajo Nation representative is therefore always present at TIBC.

are not available for 2013 and 2019, so we cannot observe TIBC participation in these years. Because participation may also reflect geographic proximity, resource availability, and administrative capacity rather than the strategic considerations in our theory, we control for these directly using the tribal characteristics described above.

As a robustness check on this coding decision, we construct an alternative measure restricted to the regional representatives. Because these seats are apportioned two per BIA region, we also estimate a version of this measure that compares tribes only within the same region-year, reflecting the fact that a tribe's competition for a regional seat is with its regional neighbors rather than with tribes elsewhere in the country.

We additionally construct subcommittee-specific engagement indicators to test whether membership on a subcommittee predicts funding in a matched policy area. Using the same directories, we code separate binary indicators for membership on the Budget, Education, Roads and Transportation, and Land, Water and Natural Resources subcommittees, which we pair respectively with total DOI funding, education funding, infrastructure funding, and environmental funding in the funding categories described below.[26]

Table 1 shows the joint distribution of the two measures across all tribes in our sample. Lobbying is substantially more common: approximately 64% of tribes lobbied at some point between 2013 and 2021, compared to roughly 17% that held a TIBC role. This is consistent with the two instances' different cost structures: TIBC offers a fixed number of seats and requires the sustained attention of tribal leadership, while lobbying carries no such limit and can be delegated to a retained firm.

Measuring Federal Transfers

Hypotheses 6 and 7 concern the returns to engagement, which we measure as federal transfers from the Department of the Interior. We pull all DOI transactions from USAspending.gov, which

[26]The Education and Roads and Transportation subcommittees first appear in our directory data in 2017, and the Land, Water and Natural Resources subcommittee first appears in 2020; treated variation for these indicators is therefore limited to the final years of our panel.

Table 1: Tribal Engagement by Type

	Lobbying	
TIBC	0	1
0	112	174
1	11	48

records transfers of money or in-kind goods to non-federal entities but excludes federal purchases of goods and services. Interior houses the two agencies with the broadest administrative responsibility for federal Indian policy, the Bureau of Indian Affairs (BIA) and Bureau of Indian Education (BIE), alongside other agencies in frequent tribal contact, including the Fish and Wildlife Service, the Bureau of Reclamation, and the National Park Service.

We identify tribal recipients by subsetting USAspending records to the Tribal Government business-type classification, which nonetheless includes non-tribal universities, grade schools, state and local governments, and private companies alongside genuine tribal recipients. We retain only transactions to entities that are a tribal government or are owned or controlled by one, connecting transactions to specific tribes via federally-assigned Unique Entity Identifier (UEI) numbers for recipients and their listed parent organizations.[27] We exclude transactions with required federal funds at or below zero, which likely represent adjustments to prior awards or other bureaucratic entries rather than substantive transfers. This yields 89,990 tribal awards out of 371,414 total DOI transactions. Figure 2 shows the resulting transaction counts and values by fiscal year and awarding agency; the large majority, by both volume and value, originate from BIA and BIE.[28]

[27] Prior to FY 2013, records were too disorganized to identify relevant transactions without significant missingness.

[28] USAspending.gov does not differentiate between these two agencies, so we cannot distinguish transactions between them.

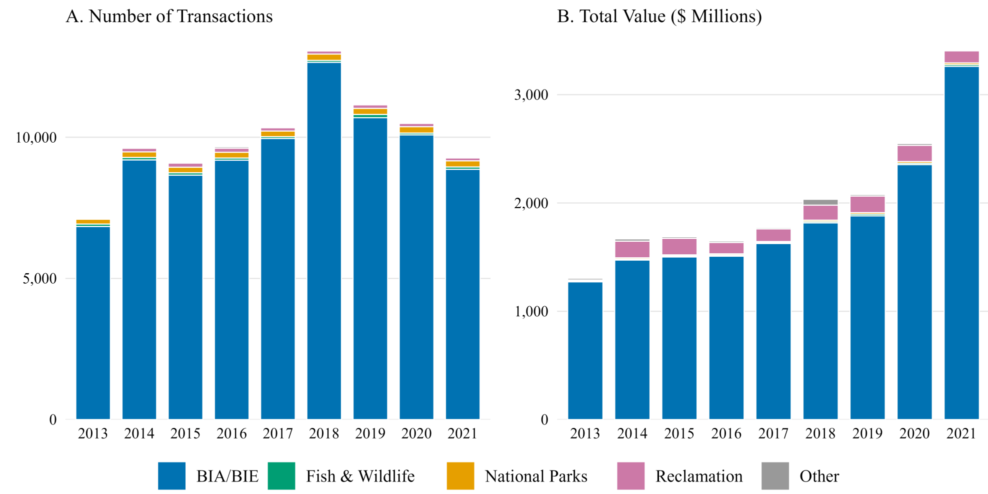

Figure 2: **DOI Transactions by Awarding Subagency** Department of the Interior transactions to tribal governments identified in USAspending.gov records, fiscal years 2013–2021 (N = 89,990 positive-obligation transactions); dollar values are nominal.

One limitation that applies to both identification strategies is that inter-tribal organizations, whose membership is not always public and may change over time, are excluded because we cannot connect their transactions to specific member tribes. This means our data understate total federal funding for any tribe that receives significant support through such an organization. A second limitation is that USAspending does not distinguish competitively awarded transactions from those arising under formula, compact, or negotiated settlement, a constraint we return to in interpreting our results.

Our primary funding measure, *Total DOI funding*, sums all qualifying transactions to a tribe in a fiscal year, logged given the substantial variation between tribes.[29] We also disaggregated total funding into five functional categories, infrastructure (physical infrastructure and economic development programs), self-determination (self-determination contracting and compacting programs and tribal government services), education, environment, and culture.

[29]We also test our results when isolating to just BIA/BIE funding. Reported in Appendix D, results are largely consistent with broader DOI funding.

Model Estimation

The unit of analysis is the tribe-fiscal year. We drop tribes reporting zero enrollment in the IHBG data, on the assumption that these reflect measurement error rather than genuine zeros, leaving 3,074 tribe-fiscal year observations.[30]

Correlates of engagement (H1–H5). We estimate linear probability models regressing each binary engagement measure on the tribal characteristics described above, with fiscal year fixed effects to absorb variation common to all tribes. For TIBC participation, we exclude Navajo Nation observations, since TIBC reserves an exclusive region for the Navajo Nation alone, invalidating any selection mechanism for the tribe.

Returns to engagement (H6–H7). We estimate tribe and fiscal year fixed-effects models, adding tribe-level linear time trends in our preferred specification. Used in other work on intergovernmental lobbying, such as Payson (2020*a*), trends address a specific endogeneity concern: tribes plausibly adjust their engagement in response to their funding trajectory, entering lobbying or TIBC when transfers are already declining or stagnant. Without a tribe-specific trend, this reverse relationship is absorbed into the engagement coefficient and biases it downward, toward finding that engagement predicts lower funding even if it has no effect or a positive one. Models without trends should therefore be read as a lower bound, and we treat the trend-inclusive specification as our preferred estimate for this reason.

We operationalize engagement in returns models two ways. A lagged specification regresses funding in year t on engagement in year $t-1$, capturing the short-run return to a single instance of engagement. A cumulative specification instead counts the number of years a tribe has engaged in lobbying or TIBC by year t, capturing the return to sustained engagement over time. Standard errors are clustered by tribe throughout.

[30]Observation counts vary modestly across specific tables depending on non-missingness requirements for the variables each model uses; we note the applicable count with each result.

Results

Correlates of Engagement

We start by examining the correlates of engagement, displayed in Table 2. Consistent with Hypothesis 1, enrollment is positively and significantly associated with lobbying and TIBC participation ($p < .01$ and $p < .01$, respectively), the only covariate to predict engagement across both instances. The remainder of the demand cluster is more uneven. Reservation land area is positively associated with lobbying ($p < .05$) but not with TIBC participation, while service area population and water area predict neither.

Hypotheses 2 and 3 receive clearer support. Gaming investment is positively and significantly associated with lobbying ($p < .01$), consistent with Hypothesis 2's expectation that tribes with a concrete regulatory interest to defend are more likely to retain representation in Washington. Gaming shows no corresponding relationship to TIBC participation, consistent with Hypothesis 3's expectation that general economic interest does little to predict a tribe's willingness to take on TIBC's demands. Poverty shows no relationship to either form of engagement, consistent with our theory's focus on gaming rather than general economic need as the relevant test of wealth.

Consistent with our expectations in Hypotheses 4 and 5, distance to the nearest city and distance to the nearest commercial airport are both negatively and significantly associated with lobbying ($p < .05$ and $p < .05$, respectively), while neither distance measure, nor distance to Washington, D.C. itself, predicts TIBC participation. The absence of a distance-to-DC effect on lobbying is worth noting in its own right: if remoteness suppressed lobbying because Washington itself was hard to reach, distance to the capital should be the most consequential measure, not the least. That it is city and airport distance, not distance to DC, that predict lobbying is consistent with our theoretical expectation that what remoteness undermines is proximity to the professional infrastructure of representation, not proximity to the seat of government as such. TIBC's insulation from all three distance measures is consistent with its regional apportionment structure, under which a tribe competes for a seat against its regional neighbors rather than against better-connected tribes elsewhere

Table 2: Correlates of Political Engagement

Hypothesis	Covariate	Lobbying	TIBC
Demand	Enrollment (log)	0.055***	0.033***
(H1)		(0.021)	(0.012)
	Population (log)	0.019	-0.008
		(0.012)	(0.006)
	Land Area (log)	0.027**	-0.000
		(0.012)	(0.004)
	Water Area (log)	-0.012	0.006
		(0.011)	(0.005)
Wealth & Gaming	Gaming (log)	0.015***	-0.002
(H2–H3)		(0.005)	(0.001)
	Poverty (log)	-0.009	-0.002
		(0.011)	(0.003)
Geography	Distance to City (log)	-0.041**	0.004
(H4–H5)		(0.021)	(0.007)
	Distance to DC (log)	-0.043	0.012
		(0.082)	(0.023)
	Distance to Airport (log)	-0.058**	-0.002
		(0.023)	(0.007)
Region	Eastern	0.167 (0.159)	-0.028 (0.074)
(ref. Great Plains)	E. Oklahoma	-0.018 (0.127)	-0.016 (0.076)
	Midwest	0.129 (0.126)	0.003 (0.071)
	Northwest	0.317** (0.128)	-0.002 (0.068)
	Pacific	0.093 (0.135)	-0.013 (0.067)
	Rocky Mountain	0.053 (0.165)	0.113 (0.100)
	Southern Plains	-0.329** (0.129)	-0.026 (0.068)
	Southwest	0.087 (0.133)	-0.017 (0.068)
	Western	-0.004 (0.136)	-0.022 (0.069)
Observations		3,074	3,065
Year FE		×	×

Notes: Linear probability models. Outcomes are any lobbying activity (column 1) and TIBC participation (column 2) in a given year. Standard errors clustered at the tribe level (region rows: in parentheses beside estimates). Navajo Nation excluded from the TIBC model because participation is guaranteed. Covariates are grouped by the hypothesis they inform; region indicators are descriptive.
* $p < 0.10$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

in the country.

Two further patterns are worth noting. Region fixed effects show that tribes in the Southern Plains region are significantly less likely to lobby than the reference category ($p < .05$), while tribes in the Northwest are significantly more likely ($p < .05$); no other region reaches significance for lobbying, and no region predicts TIBC participation. We treat these regional differences as descriptive rather than as tests of any hypothesis, though they remain interesting insights into the patterning of engagement worth further investigation. Second, enrollment aside, none of our demand, wealth, or geography measures reach significance in the TIBC model. Participation in TIBC appears to be a decision shaped by considerations other than the structural characteristics that predict lobbying, plausibly closer to individual tribal leadership or local political culture than to the tribal-level covariates available in administrative data.

As a robustness check, in Table 3 we re-estimate the TIBC model restricting participation to the two regional representative seats specifically, excluding co-chairs and subcommittee roles, and further restrict comparisons to within region-year to more closely reflect the two-seat allocation structure. Enrollment remains the only covariate approaching significance, though its coefficient attenuates and its significance weakens from $p < .01$ in the pooled model to $p < .10$ under the more restrictive within-region-year specification. No other covariate reaches significance in either specification. This suggests our substantive conclusion, that TIBC participation is not well explained by the tribal characteristics that predict lobbying, is not an artifact of how broadly we code participation.

Returns to Engagement

We next turn to the financial returns to engagement, reported in Table 4. Columns 1 and 2 omit tribe-level linear time trends; column 3, our preferred specification for the reasons discussed above, includes them. The contrast between these specifications is itself informative. In Panel A, where funding is measured in raw dollars, both cumulative measures load positively and significantly in the absence of trends: cumulative lobbying enters at 596,625 and 620,564 ($p < .01$) and cumulative TIBC participation at 939,643 and 938,608 ($p < .05$) across columns 1 and 2. We do not read

Table 3: Correlates of TIBC Engagement: Any Participation vs. Regional Representative Seat

	Any Participation	Regional Rep Seat
Enrollment (log)	0.033***	0.021*
	(0.012)	(0.011)
Population (log)	-0.008	-0.006
	(0.006)	(0.006)
Poverty (log)	-0.002	-0.001
	(0.003)	(0.002)
Land Area (log)	-0.000	-0.002
	(0.004)	(0.003)
Water Area (log)	0.006	0.004
	(0.005)	(0.004)
Gaming (log)	-0.002	-0.002
	(0.001)	(0.001)
Distance to City (log)	0.004	0.002
	(0.007)	(0.006)
Distance to DC (log)	0.012	0.007
	(0.023)	(0.019)
Distance to Airport (log)	-0.002	-0.004
	(0.007)	(0.006)
Observations	3,065	3,065
Year FE	×	
BIA Region dummies	×	
Region × Year FE		×

Notes: Standard errors clustered at the tribe level. Navajo Nation excluded from both models. Column 1 reproduces the pooled participation model (BIA region dummies not shown). Column 2 restricts comparisons to within region-year: regional representative seats are allocated two per BIA region, so covariates are identified from which tribes within a region hold its seats. * $p < 0.10$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

these as returns. Engagement is concentrated among larger tribes, which receive larger absolute transfers, so a dollar-denominated specification that does not absorb tribe-specific trajectories recovers this cross-sectional association between scale and engagement rather than any within-tribe effect. The remaining panels, which scale funding by population or estimate it in logs, net out precisely this source of variation, and the sign of the relationship reverses accordingly. Without trends, cumulative TIBC participation is associated with significant declines in both logged and per-capita DOI funding across columns 1 and 2 ($p < .05$ or better throughout, reaching $p < .01$ for per-capita funding once controls are added). Cumulative lobbying shows a related but less consistent pattern: it is marginally associated with a decline in logged funding before controls are added ($p < .10$), a relationship that disappears once controls enter even prior to the inclusion of trends, but remains significantly associated with declining per-capita funding across both columns ($p < .05$). Once tribe-specific trends are added in column 3, every one of these negative coefficients loses significance, as do the positive raw-dollar coefficients in Panel A. This pattern is consistent with the endogeneity concern we raised in describing our estimation strategy: tribes are more likely to take up engagement precisely when their funding trajectory is already flat or declining, which absorbs into the treatment coefficient as spurious negative returns unless tribe-specific trajectories are held constant.

In our preferred specification, evidence for Hypothesis 6 is weak. Of the twelve engagement coefficients reported across the three funding measures in column 3, only one crosses even a ten-percent threshold: the lagged effect of TIBC participation on total dollar funding is positive and marginally significant ($p < .10$). This coefficient does not survive the transformation to logged or per-capita funding, and it is a single result out of twelve, roughly the number one would expect to cross a ten-percent threshold by chance alone. We do not read it as reliable evidence that TIBC participation increases funding. The remaining eleven coefficients, spanning both forms of engagement, both operationalizations (lagged and cumulative), and all three funding measures, are statistically indistinguishable from zero. This pattern is far more consistent with Hypothesis 7 than with Hypothesis 6: engagement, once endogenous selection into engagement is accounted

Table 4: Effects of Political Engagement on DOI Funding

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Panel A: DOI Funding ($)			
Lobbying$_{t-1}$	-244194	-229960	175665
	(220541)	(221289)	(237423)
TIBC$_{t-1}$	3092209	3106805	1494283*
	(2240158)	(2240395)	(900286)
Lobbying (cumulative)	596625***	620564***	50412
	(201163)	(202543)	(187116)
TIBC (cumulative)	939643**	938608**	358200
	(404732)	(402602)	(221037)
Panel B: Log DOI Funding			
Lobbying$_{t-1}$	0.090	0.083	0.035
	(0.148)	(0.150)	(0.073)
TIBC$_{t-1}$	-0.033	-0.043	-0.000
	(0.040)	(0.046)	(0.040)
Lobbying (cumulative)	-0.049*	-0.049	0.146
	(0.030)	(0.030)	(0.220)
TIBC (cumulative)	-0.030**	-0.031**	-0.011
	(0.012)	(0.013)	(0.014)
Panel C: Per Capita DOI Funding			
Lobbying$_{t-1}$	-115.31	-165.66	1.00
	(207.81)	(219.34)	(208.43)
TIBC$_{t-1}$	-190.38*	-255.65*	-36.35
	(110.71)	(132.58)	(92.97)
Lobbying (cumulative)	-168.96**	-170.31**	82.97
	(67.98)	(75.49)	(116.21)
TIBC (cumulative)	-91.87**	-111.78***	-32.63
	(36.98)	(42.79)	(27.23)
Observations	3,064	3,064	3,064
Controls		×	×
Tribe FE	×	×	×
Year FE	×	×	×
Tribe linear trends			×

Notes: Standard errors clustered at the tribe level. Controls include log enrollment, log reservation population, log land area, log water area, log households below 30% of median HH income (scaled by AIAN population), and log total slot machines.
* $p < 0.10$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

for, does not detectably increase the aggregate federal funding tribes receive.

Funding Categories and Subcommittee Effects

A null aggregate effect could still mask engagement's influence on particular kinds of funding, so we disaggregate total DOI funding into five functional categories and re-estimate our preferred (tribe linear trends) specification for each. Figure 3 plots the resulting coefficients.[31] Consistent with the aggregate results above, the overwhelming majority of these estimates are statistically indistinguishable from zero. The single exception is infrastructure funding, where the lagged effect of lobbying is negative and significant ($p < .05$); no other category-treatment combination reaches significance, including the lagged and cumulative TIBC coefficients or any cumulative lobbying coefficient. Given that this is one significant result among twenty coefficients estimated across five funding categories and four engagement measures, we treat it cautiously rather than as a robust finding, and note that a negative return to lobbying on infrastructure funding specifically would in any case run in the opposite direction from what a fiscal-returns account would predict.

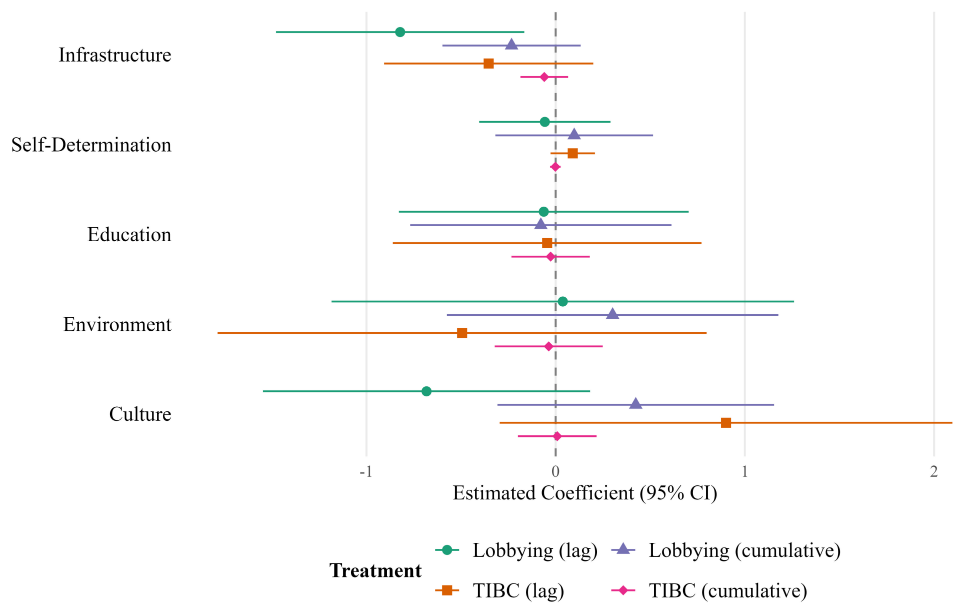

Figure 3: **Effects of Lobbying and TIBC participation on Funding by Category** Coefficients on lagged and cumulative engagement from separate regressions of each logged funding category, estimated with tribe and year fixed effects, controls, and tribe linear trends. Bars are 95% confidence intervals; standard errors clustered by tribe. Full results in Appendix E.

[31] Tables with exact estimates are available in Appendix E.

Because TIBC seats representatives on subcommittees devoted to specific policy areas, we further test whether membership on a subcommittee predicts funding in the matched category: budget subcommittee membership and total DOI funding, education subcommittee membership and education funding, roads and transportation subcommittee membership and infrastructure funding, and land, water, and natural resources subcommittee membership and environmental funding. Table 5 reports the results. Budget subcommittee membership shows no relationship to total funding in any specification. The roads and transportation and land and water subcommittees show no relationship to their matched funding categories either, though these null results should be interpreted with caution: both subcommittees first appear in our directory data only in the final years of the panel, leaving few treated tribe-years to identify an effect and correspondingly wide confidence intervals.

The one result that departs from the null pattern is education subcommittee membership, which is positively and significantly associated with education funding once tribal controls are added ($p < .05$). This relationship does not survive the inclusion of tribe linear trends, our preferred specification throughout, and given the limited number of tribes ever seated on the education subcommittee in our data, we are underpowered to detect an effect of this kind reliably even if one exists.

As an additional robustness check, we re-estimate our primary specifications using two- and three-year lags in place of the one-year lag reported above, motivated by the fact that TIBC's budget discussions often concern appropriations cycles several years ahead rather than the immediate fiscal year. Results are reported in Appendix F. Most effects remain null, consistent with the one-year lag results. However, two relationships are statistically significant with a two-year lag and tribe time trends. First, self-determination funding increased two years after TIBC participation. Second, education funding increased two years after the tribe participated in the Education subcommittee at TIBC. Neither effect was observed with a three-year lag.

Table 5: Effects of TIBC Subcommittee Membership on Matched Funding Categories

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Committee$_{t-1}$ $\rightarrow$ *Matched Outcome (log)*			
Budget $\rightarrow$ Total DOI	-0.022	-0.023	-0.011
	(0.079)	(0.079)	(0.081)
Education $\rightarrow$ Education	0.324	0.480**	0.083
	(0.198)	(0.196)	(0.149)
Roads/Transp. $\rightarrow$ Infrastructure	-0.676	-0.632	-0.704
	(0.649)	(0.708)	(0.720)
Land/Water $\rightarrow$ Conservation	1.000	0.993	0.195
	(1.816)	(1.811)	(1.621)
Observations	3,064	3,064	3,064
Controls		×	×
Tribe FE	×	×	×
Year FE	×	×	×
Tribe linear trends			×

Notes: Each row reports the coefficient on the lagged subcommittee membership indicator from a separate regression of the matched (logged) funding category. Standard errors clustered at the tribe level. Controls include log enrollment, log reservation population, log land area, log water area, log households below 30% of median HH income (scaled by AIAN population), and log total slot machines. The Education, Roads, and Land/Water subcommittees first appear in directories in 2017, 2017, and 2020 respectively, so treated variation for those rows is limited to the final panel years.
* $p < 0.10$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

Summary of Findings

Taken together, these results support a consistent picture across both stages of our analysis. Which tribes engage is reasonably well explained by our theory for lobbying, where enrollment, gaming investment, and geographic proximity to cities and airports all predict participation in the directions Hypotheses 1, 2, and 4 anticipate. TIBC participation is explained far less well by the same characteristics, with enrollment the only consistent predictor, a pattern that holds when we restrict the measure to regional representative seats specifically.

Whether engagement pays off in additional federal funding receives little support once we account for the endogenous relationship between funding trajectories and the decision to engage. Our preferred specification detects no reliable returns to either form of engagement on total, logged, or per-capita DOI funding, nor on funding disaggregated by category, with the exception of a handful of fragile results we do not treat as robust given the number of coefficients tested. This pattern is consistent with Hypothesis 7 rather than Hypothesis 6 where engagement appears to serve tribes in ways that do not register as growth in the federal funding they receive.

Discussion

We examine how and why tribal governments engage with the U.S. federal government, and whether that engagement affects the federal funding tribes receive. We distinguish two forms of engagement, persuasion and learning, and argue that they are patterned by different considerations and should be expected to deliver different kinds of returns. Using original data on tribal lobbying disclosures and Tribal-Interior Budget Council (TIBC) participation, alongside a newly constructed dataset of federal transfers to tribal governments, we find that lobbying is well explained by tribal demand, gaming investment, and geographic proximity to the professional infrastructure of representation. However, TIBC participation is explained by almost none of these characteristics, with enrollment the lone exception. Once we account for the tendency of tribes to take up engagement precisely when their funding trajectory is already declining, neither form of engagement shows a reliable relationship to the federal funding tribes subsequently receive.

This paper makes three contributions. First, by treating engagement as a process of learning as well as persuasion, we connect tribal governance to broader accounts of how governments in federal systems acquire and act on information, rather than treating advocacy as the only channel through which subnational governments engage the institutions that fund them. Existing work on tribal political behavior has largely followed the subnational lobbying literature in focusing on persuasion; our results suggest that a second logic, oriented toward navigating a policy environment tribes cannot readily change, organizes a substantial share of tribal engagement, and does so on different terms than persuasion does.

Second, by documenting limited financial returns to engagement where the intergovernmental lobbying literature more broadly has found substantial ones, we identify a scope condition on that literature that returns to engagement plausibly depend on how much discretion exists in the funding stream being targeted. A large share of Interior funding to tribes is anchored to allocation baselines set decades earlier and carried forward with limited revision. Where this is true, engagement should not be expected to move the aggregate, whatever else it accomplishes, and our results are consistent with that expectation rather than with a straightforward extension of findings from municipal or state-level lobbying to the tribal case.

Third, by assembling original data linking just under 90,000 Department of the Interior transactions to individual tribal governments, we provide the most detailed quantitative account to date of the tribal-federal fiscal relationship. This dataset, and the measures of engagement we pair with it, offer a foundation other researchers can build on to examine tribal-federal financial flows beyond the scope of this paper.

Several extensions follow directly from what this study has established. The measurement strategy and dataset developed here, linking individual tribal governments to federal transactions and to two distinct instances of political engagement, provide a template that can be extended beyond the Department of the Interior. Interior houses the agencies most directly responsible for federal Indian policy, but tribes maintain substantial financial relationships with other departments as well, including Health and Human Services, Education, and the Environmental Protection

Agency. Applying the same engagement measures and identification strategy to these departments would establish whether the patterns we document, persuasion well-explained by structural characteristics, learning poorly explained by them, and limited aggregate returns to either, are specific to Interior's institutional context or characterize the tribal-federal fiscal relationship more broadly.

Second, our correlates results raise a question we cannot answer within the scope of this study. Enrollment aside, none of the tribal characteristics available to us predict TIBC participation, even when we restrict the measure to regional representative seats specifically. Whatever leads a tribe to take up TIBC's demands, the structural account that explains lobbying does not explain it. Interview-based research with TIBC representatives and the tribal leaders who nominate them is well positioned to close this gap, surfacing what draws particular tribes toward a demanding, low-payoff form of engagement while so many similarly situated tribes do not participate. Such work would pair the structural account we offer for lobbying with an account of TIBC participation grounded in the individual and cultural considerations our data cannot currently reach.

Third, the framework itself need not stop at the federal boundary. Many states maintain their own tribal consultation bodies, gaming compacts, and revenue-sharing arrangements, government-to-government relationships that pose the same choice between persuasion and learning we study here. Extending our approach to the state level would show whether these two forms of engagement organize tribal-state relations the same way they organize the tribal-federal relationship, and whether state allocation structures impose a similar constraint on returns. Either result would sharpen what we can say about federal Indian policy specifically where confirmation would suggest a general feature of how tribes navigate government funding, while divergence would help isolate what is distinctive about the federal case.

Our results carry a specific implication for how tribal fiscal autonomy should be understood. If a substantial share of Interior funding is anchored to allocation baselines set decades ago and carried forward with limited revision, a tribe's fiscal position in a given year depends less on how effectively its leadership engages federal institutions than on allocation decisions made long before current leadership took office and rarely revisited since. This is a structural claim about the funding environment tribes operate within, not a claim about the value of engagement itself. Learning what a tribe is already eligible for, and defending existing allocations against erosion, are forms of value that would not register as funding growth in data like ours but plausibly matter a great deal to the tribes that pursue them. The absence of a detectable aggregate return is therefore better read as evidence about where discretion exists in the tribal-federal fiscal relationship than as evidence that tribal political engagement is ineffective. Understanding tribal fiscal autonomy requires attention to how funding streams are structured, and which of them retain genuine discretion, not only to how actively tribes engage the institutions that administer them.

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Online Appendix

Persuasion and Learning: Exploring Tribal Engagement and the Politics of Federal Support

A Cherokee Budget Federal Funding by Department

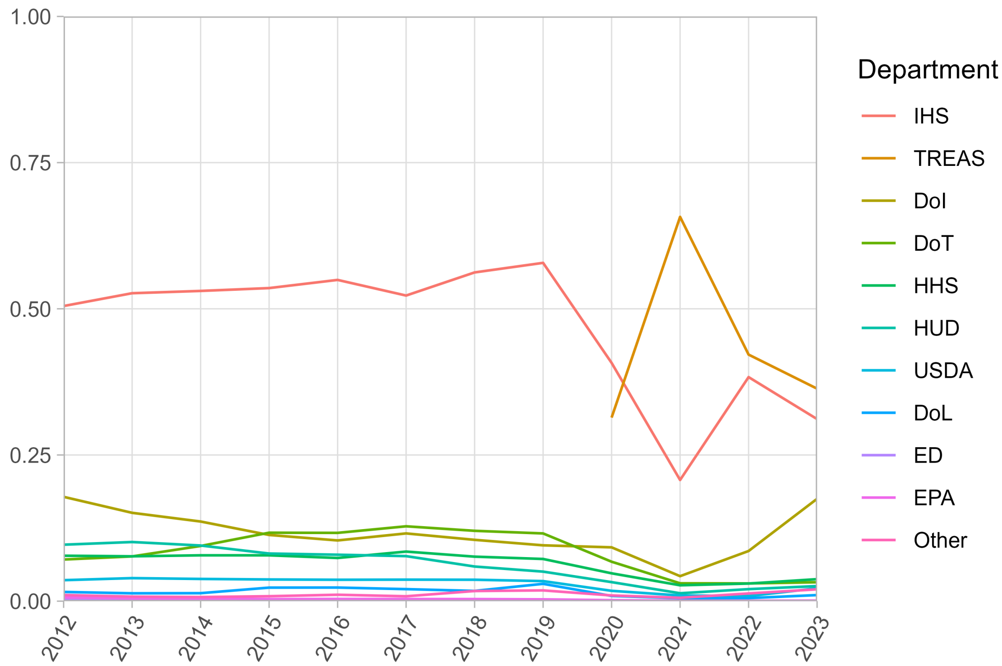

Figure A1: Breakdown of the federally-justified portion of the Cherokee Nation budget by department (includes both the operating and capital budgets).

B Interior Funding to Gaming Tribes as a Percentage of Gaming Revenue

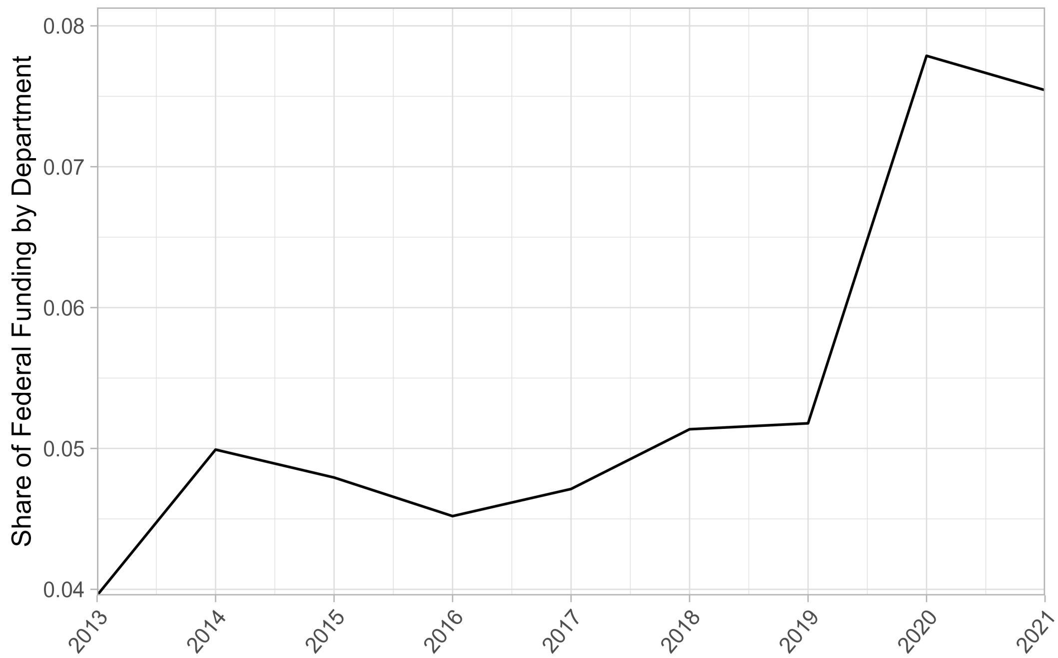

Figure A2: A comparison of Interior funding to all gaming tribes in a fiscal year to the total gaming revenue earned by gaming sites, as reported by the NIGC.

C Effects of Lobbying (High Spending) on DOI Funding

Table A1: Effects of High Lobbying Expenditure on DOI Funding

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Panel A: DOI Funding ($)			
Lobbying$_{t-1}$	-211711	-208894	414200
	(259152)	(257737)	(287736)
Lobbying $\geq$ \$100k$_{t-1}$	291268	305833	-1257791
	(520538)	(524139)	(822917)
Panel B: Log DOI Funding			
Lobbying$_{t-1}$	0.067	0.060	0.045
	(0.097)	(0.098)	(0.065)
Lobbying $\geq$ \$100k$_{t-1}$	0.043	0.039	-0.042
	(0.113)	(0.115)	(0.053)
Panel C: Per Capita DOI Funding			
Lobbying$_{t-1}$	20.81	-26.85	130.42
	(210.38)	(221.40)	(249.38)
Lobbying $\geq$ \$100k$_{t-1}$	-304.16*	-323.15*	-163.60
	(159.67)	(165.73)	(129.40)
Observations	3,028	3,028	3,028
Controls		×	×
Tribe FE	×	×	×
Year FE	×	×	×
Tribe linear trends			×

Notes: Each column reports coefficients from a single regression including both lobbying indicators. Lobbying$_{t-1}$ is a binary indicator for any lobbying activity in the prior year. Lobbying $\geq$ \$100k$_{t-1}$ is a binary indicator for spending at least \$100,000 on lobbying in the prior year (75th percentile of the pooled sample). Standard errors clustered at the tribe level. Controls include log enrollment, log reservation population, log land area, log water area, log households below 30% of median HH income (scaled by AIAN population), and log total slot machines.
* $p < 0.10$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

D Effects of Engagement on BIA/BIE Funding

Table A2: Effects of Political Engagement on BIA/BIE Funding

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Panel A: BIA/BIE Funding ($)			
Lobbying$_{t-1}$	-113760	-97554	227948
	(216448)	(217373)	(234617)
TIBC$_{t-1}$	2862813	2879767	1107877
	(2207621)	(2208112)	(806449)
Lobbying (cumulative)	604048***	626292***	8977
	(198667)	(200263)	(194253)
TIBC (cumulative)	811044**	810340**	225272
	(364419)	(362156)	(143220)
Panel B: Log BIA/BIE Funding			
Lobbying$_{t-1}$	0.050	0.055	-0.069
	(0.159)	(0.160)	(0.160)
TIBC$_{t-1}$	-0.052	-0.048	-0.034
	(0.045)	(0.050)	(0.046)
Lobbying (cumulative)	-0.059*	-0.058*	0.036
	(0.030)	(0.031)	(0.255)
TIBC (cumulative)	-0.038***	-0.037**	-0.022
	(0.014)	(0.015)	(0.014)
Panel C: Per Capita BIA/BIE Funding			
Lobbying$_{t-1}$	-81.84	-131.74	23.48
	(207.53)	(218.94)	(211.93)
TIBC$_{t-1}$	-166.93	-231.12*	-36.60
	(108.42)	(130.25)	(94.12)
Lobbying (cumulative)	-150.18**	-152.60**	56.08
	(67.16)	(75.52)	(127.17)
TIBC (cumulative)	-89.86**	-108.99***	-33.69
	(35.55)	(41.51)	(26.30)
Observations	3,064	3,064	3,064
Controls		×	×
Tribe FE	×	×	×
Year FE	×	×	×
Tribe linear trends			×

Notes: Standard errors clustered at the tribe level. Controls include log enrollment, log reservation population, log land area, log water area, log households below 30% of median HH income (scaled by AIAN population), and log total slot machines.
* $p < 0.10$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

E Effects of Engagement on Funding by Category

Table A3: Effects of Political Engagement on Infrastructure Funding

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Lobbying$_{t-1}$	-0.174	-0.153	-0.822**
	(0.354)	(0.359)	(0.335)
TIBC$_{t-1}$	0.130	0.166	-0.354
	(0.438)	(0.439)	(0.282)
Lobbying (cumulative)	0.010	0.005	-0.233
	(0.101)	(0.102)	(0.186)
TIBC (cumulative)	0.078	0.084	-0.060
	(0.093)	(0.093)	(0.064)
Observations	3,064	3,064	3,064
Controls		×	×
Tribe FE	×	×	×
Year FE	×	×	×
Tribe linear trends			×

Notes: Outcome is logged. Standard errors clustered at the tribe level. Controls include log enrollment, log reservation population, log land area, log water area, log households below 30% of median HH income (scaled by AIAN population), and log total slot machines.
* $p < 0.10$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A4: Effects of Political Engagement on Self-Determination Funding

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Lobbying$_{t-1}$	0.207	0.216	-0.057
	(0.188)	(0.188)	(0.177)
TIBC$_{t-1}$	-0.007	-0.005	0.090
	(0.065)	(0.068)	(0.060)
Lobbying (cumulative)	-0.048	-0.046	0.098
	(0.033)	(0.034)	(0.213)
TIBC (cumulative)	-0.045***	-0.046***	-0.002
	(0.016)	(0.017)	(0.014)
Observations	3,064	3,064	3,064
Controls		×	×
Tribe FE	×	×	×
Year FE	×	×	×
Tribe linear trends			×

Notes: Outcome is logged. Standard errors clustered at the tribe level. Controls include log enrollment, log reservation population, log land area, log water area, log households below 30% of median HH income (scaled by AIAN population), and log total slot machines.
* $p < 0.10$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A5: Effects of Political Engagement on Education Funding

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Lobbying_{t-1}	-0.452	-0.435	-0.063
	(0.284)	(0.284)	(0.391)
TIBC_{t-1}	-0.027	0.005	-0.045
	(0.518)	(0.517)	(0.416)
Lobbying (cumulative)	0.094	0.096	-0.078
	(0.124)	(0.118)	(0.352)
TIBC (cumulative)	-0.134*	-0.125*	-0.027
	(0.068)	(0.067)	(0.106)
Observations	3,064	3,064	3,064
Controls		×	×
Tribe FE	×	×	×
Year FE	×	×	×
Tribe linear trends			×

Notes: Outcome is logged. Standard errors clustered at the tribe level. Controls include log enrollment, log reservation population, log land area, log water area, log households below 30% of median HH income (scaled by AIAN population), and log total slot machines.
* $p < 0.10$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A6: Effects of Political Engagement on Environment Funding

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Lobbying_{t-1}	0.114	0.051	0.038
	(0.517)	(0.515)	(0.624)
TIBC_{t-1}	-0.111	-0.083	-0.494
	(0.641)	(0.643)	(0.659)
Lobbying (cumulative)	-0.214	-0.195	0.301
	(0.193)	(0.181)	(0.447)
TIBC (cumulative)	0.053	0.059	-0.037
	(0.101)	(0.100)	(0.146)
Observations	3,064	3,064	3,064
Controls		×	×
Tribe FE	×	×	×
Year FE	×	×	×
Tribe linear trends			×

Notes: Outcome is logged. Standard errors clustered at the tribe level. Controls include log enrollment, log reservation population, log land area, log water area, log households below 30% of median HH income (scaled by AIAN population), and log total slot machines.
* $p < 0.10$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A7: Effects of Political Engagement on Culture Funding

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Lobbying_{t-1}	-0.673*	-0.682*	-0.683
	(0.400)	(0.396)	(0.441)
TIBC_{t-1}	0.761	0.806	0.900
	(0.506)	(0.509)	(0.610)
Lobbying (cumulative)	0.140	0.130	0.423
	(0.091)	(0.092)	(0.373)
TIBC (cumulative)	0.117	0.134	0.008
	(0.100)	(0.100)	(0.106)
Observations	3,064	3,064	3,064
Controls		×	×
Tribe FE	×	×	×
Year FE	×	×	×
Tribe linear trends			×

Notes: Outcome is logged. Standard errors clustered at the tribe level. Controls include log enrollment, log reservation population, log land area, log water area, log households below 30% of median HH income (scaled by AIAN population), and log total slot machines.
* $p < 0.10$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

F Effects of Lobbying and TIBC Participation with Multi-year Lags

Table A8: Effects of Political Engagement on DOI Funding at Longer Lags

	Treatment$_{t-2}$		Treatment$_{t-3}$	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Lobbying	0.029	0.045	-0.004	0.060
	(0.056)	(0.127)	(0.114)	(0.252)
TIBC	0.045	0.074	-0.036	0.044
	(0.044)	(0.050)	(0.045)	(0.051)
Observations	3,064	3,064	3,064	3,064
Controls	×	×	×	×
Tribe FE	×	×	×	×
Year FE	×	×	×	×
Tribe linear trends		×		×

Notes: Each cell reports the coefficient on the indicated lag of the treatment from a separate regression. Deeper lags reflect the federal budget cycle: engagement in year t primarily concerns budgets formulated two to three fiscal years ahead. Standard errors clustered at the tribe level. Controls include log enrollment, log reservation population, log land area, log water area, log households below 30% of median HH income (scaled by AIAN population), and log total slot machines.
* $p < 0.10$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A9: Effects of Political Engagement on Funding Categories at Longer Lags

	Treatment$_{t-2}$		Treatment$_{t-3}$	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Panel A: Lobbying				
Infrastructure	0.151	-0.181	0.152	-0.126
	(0.377)	(0.402)	(0.434)	(0.392)
Self-Determination	0.153	-0.018	0.231	0.218
	(0.138)	(0.142)	(0.195)	(0.251)
Education	-0.426*	-0.160	-0.222	0.302
	(0.232)	(0.244)	(0.335)	(0.402)
Environment	0.131	0.219	0.002	-0.122
	(0.504)	(0.593)	(0.531)	(0.645)
Culture	-0.356	-0.188	0.189	0.849*
	(0.335)	(0.374)	(0.341)	(0.460)
Panel B: TIBC				
Infrastructure	-0.094	0.036	-0.056	0.007
	(0.478)	(0.359)	(0.437)	(0.311)
Self-Determination	0.111*	0.129**	-0.013	0.049
	(0.062)	(0.057)	(0.077)	(0.074)
Education	0.546	0.622	-0.101	0.021
	(0.440)	(0.475)	(0.415)	(0.476)
Environment	-0.277	-0.926	0.982	0.560
	(0.651)	(0.579)	(0.706)	(0.713)
Culture	0.405	0.290	0.583	0.139
	(0.480)	(0.492)	(0.471)	(0.565)
Observations	3,064	3,064	3,064	3,064
Controls	×	×	×	×
Tribe FE	×	×	×	×
Year FE	×	×	×	×
Tribe linear trends		×		×

Notes: Each cell reports the coefficient on the indicated lag of the treatment from a separate regression. Deeper lags reflect the federal budget cycle: engagement in year t primarily concerns budgets formulated two to three fiscal years ahead. Standard errors clustered at the tribe level. Controls include log enrollment, log reservation population, log land area, log water area, log households below 30% of median HH income (scaled by AIAN population), and log total slot machines. Outcomes are the logged funding categories.
* $p < 0.10$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A10: Effects of TIBC Subcommittee Membership on Matched Categories at Longer Lags

	Treatment_{t-2}		Treatment_{t-3}	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Budget → Total DOI	0.130**	0.116	0.002	0.018
	(0.060)	(0.076)	(0.074)	(0.097)
Education → Education	0.694***	0.433**	0.647**	0.242
	(0.202)	(0.173)	(0.262)	(0.371)
Roads/Transp. → Infrastructure	-1.207***	-0.122	-1.690***	-0.061
	(0.223)	(0.274)	(0.298)	(0.340)
Land/Water → Conservation	—	—	—	—
Observations	3,064	3,064	3,064	3,064
Controls	×	×	×	×
Tribe FE	×	×	×	×
Year FE	×	×	×	×
Tribe linear trends		×		×

Notes: Each cell reports the coefficient on the indicated lag of the treatment from a separate regression. Deeper lags reflect the federal budget cycle: engagement in year t primarily concerns budgets formulated two to three fiscal years ahead. Standard errors clustered at the tribe level. Controls include log enrollment, log reservation population, log land area, log water area, log households below 30% of median HH income (scaled by AIAN population), and log total slot machines. Dashes indicate the lagged treatment has no variation within the panel: Land/Water membership begins in 2020, so its two- and three-year lags fall outside the 2013–2021 panel.

* $p < 0.10$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.